

Plenty of excursions are on offer, the highlight being a two-hour drive to Nathu La (14,140 ft), climbing up to the Indo-China border as the lush prettiness of the hill town gives way to the haunting beauty of the Himalayas. Expansive valleys, frequent waterfalls, rich mist, and then the journey above the tree line. Now, frozen mountain streams shine, red and brown shrubs sprout and, finally, it all gives way to an empire of snow. Nathu La was part of an offshoot of the historic Silk Route between India and China, with tea and horses being the main trade through the mountain pass. When we reach here, we are travelling in the footsteps of traders, pilgrims, soldiers and nomads. The thrill of being at the border of two countries is undeniable (but you cannot take photos anymore).

However high-end our travel plan, we all prove our essential Indianness by slurping Maggi on mountain visits and here the opportunity is provided by dhabas at the glorious Tsomgo Lake on the way back. The yaks are as beautiful, majestic and aloof as the Kanchenjunga.

The Nathu La day is an excellent day to book a spa treatment and surrender to the healing hands of the masseurs—in my case the excellent Dolma. At some point, the rain medley in the background, the just-so pressure of her hands, the fragrance of the oil, all merge into one undifferentiated sensorium. I am now primed for the Sikkimese thali—crisp karela, local greens, a creamy hill daal to die for, with millet rotis and a sublime chilli that has clearly been left to marinate in mustard oil since Danny was young.

Mindful of the lush red rhododendrons flowering on the grounds, and the lovely Guras tea that had welcomed me, and the Guras wine lying in my room, I enter a spirit of all or nothing and try the rhododendron cheesecake. It is great, as is all the food I try at Machan, the all-day restaurant. Full of natural light, with outdoor terrace seating that makes the heart sing (because it, well, faces the Kanchenjunga), and an enjoyable variety of dishes, Machan is a delightful locus of the resort's socio-gastronomic life.

THE INFORMATION

HOW TO REACH: Bagdogra airport (120 km from Gangtok; 4.30 hrs) is connected to Delhi, Mumbai, Chennai, Hyderabad, Bengaluru, Jaipur, Ahmedabad, Kolkata and other cities. Taj Guras Kutir is 11 km (40 min) ahead of Gangtok. Airport transfer by Taj Rs 9,500 one way. Sikkim Tourism chopper service in good weather Rs 4,500 per head

TARIFF: Deluxe rooms Rs 20,000 onwards; Suites Rs 35,000 onwards

RESTAURANTS: All-day multi-cuisine restaurant; speciality Asian food restaurant; bar

EXPERIENCES: Local village trek; forest walk; camping experience for children (1 hr); trips to Tsomgo Lake, Nathu La, the zoo, Rumtek Monastery and local view points; picnic at Fambong Lho sanctuary; picnic by waterfall; Honeymooner's Special and more

PS: Battery-operated buggies within the resort. Play area for children. No swimming pool but jacuzzi in spa area

